



Security Watch

The Microsoft COM+ Vulnerability

The Problem

On October 11, Microsoft released nine new security updates; three rated critical. All current versions of Windows are affected by some of them. One of the vulnerabilities covered by this alert, MS05-051, is being rated by Microsoft Support as "Extremely Critical". They recommend that all machines running Windows 2000 SP4 and Windows XP Pro SP1 install the MS05-051 patch immediately.

This is because of a "local privilege elevation" vulnerability that exists in the Microsoft COM+. Microsoft COM+ is used to handle resource management tasks, such as thread allocation and security on Windows OSes.

The Damages

Some of the vulnerabilities reported and addressed can result in system-level compromise without direct user interaction. Others can result in compromise if the user opens a maliciously-constructed HTML e-mail message or Web page.

Precautions

You can use Windows Update to download and install the current patches. You can also visit www.stanford.edu/services/securecomputing/alerts/windows-ms05-oct.html. The Microsoft page for the most crucial of the issues is at www.microsoft.com/technet/security/bulletin/MS05-051.mspx.

the world. It's an established fact that India is one of the largest contributors to software piracy, percentage-wise. Though it's debatable whether this has actually hurt Microsoft or just meant less profits over the years, Microsoft has finally decided that enough is enough!

Microsoft's Legal Affairs Head, Bradford Smith, announced early in October that the Windows XP Starter Edition would, for the first time, be now available in English for Indian users. Though Microsoft has thus far only provided regional language Windows XP Starter Editions to various countries, India will get this "special privilege" due to the high penetration of English-literate users.

The company hopes to reduce piracy levels by pricing this product at around Rs 1,000, which

might actually make a complete, Windows-based, sub-Rs 10,000 PC a reality. Another reason for this move could also be the fact that, thus far, sub-Rs 10,000 PCs have always included Linux as the OS of 'choice'!

Yes we applaud Microsoft for taking the initiative but it still remains to be seen whether the computer savvy populous India will settle for a Windows XP that has terribly low resolutions and a limitation of a maximum three open windows or programs—especially when the "full, (ahem) free version" is available, just by dropping in at the neighbourhood geek's house with a blank CD!

The gradual increase of 'broadband/always-on' connections in India has also spelt disaster for most software firms, not just Microsoft, as cracked versions are just a download away.

Though this move by Microsoft might increase the number of paid software subscribers in India, we doubt it's going to budge stubborn pirates. Now what would really be nice is to see a full version of Windows XP that doesn't cost the same as two or three month's salary!



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

HOT

Wi-Fi Digital Camera



What could be better than being able to transfer your pictures directly from your camera to a PC? It sounds like great news for the Papparazzi, because now they don't have to worry about film and memory cards being snatched by celebs!

Digital Camera

Wi-Fi is the way to be and if you're not moving forward, you must be going backwards! The same can be said of ordinary non-Wi-Fi digicams. They're still very good but with not concurrent with the flexibility Wi-Fi offers.



WE WERE EXPECTING THIS

Apple's 'Video iPod Launch'

The iPod may have invaded the world, but the geeks complained about better players offering video playback as well. As far as portable music went, iPods ruled, as far as portable media players went, the iPods stood idly by.

Well, Apple's not been known to let anyone beat them in terms of coolness for long. So, as expected, the Video iPod was put in the pipeline, and was recently launched.

The new iPod avatar comes in 30 and 60 GB



One Silly Question "Where is the Internet stored?"



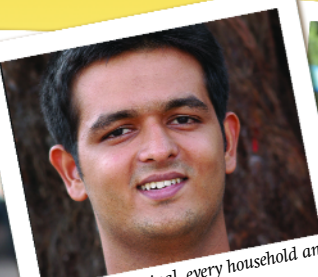
"In the brain of every computer-literate person!"

Saumil Gopani, Mumbai



"In cyberspace!"

Ami Shah, Mumbai



"On every terminal, every household and every office."

Nishant Kaushik, Ahmedabad



"It isn't stored anywhere—it comes alive through servers."

Priya Patel, Mumbai



"In an Internet café!"

Ashok Upadhyay, Nagpur